

ARUN KUMAR

Q. Why not implement it in Punjab where you are in power?
It is this policy that is now in [force in] Punjab, with some tweaks. Before it, Punjab's excise revenue was around Rs 6,000 crore. Now, I believe, it is Rs 10,000 crore.

Q. So why didn't you fight them politically to defend the policy?
We are fighting the BJP, a party that does not believe in education and healthcare. It does not believe in the Constitution either. They just like creating hypothetical situations. We made the policy for the people of Delhi. Like we made the mohalla clinics and the schools. They made an issue of that also.

Q. Do you think AAP's image, and that of the anti-corruption movement, has been dented by the 'liquor scam'?
The BJP leaders allege on TV that we took kickbacks worth Rs 1,000 crore. In court, they allege it's Rs 45 crore or whatnot. Time will give a befitting reply to such allegations. They threw so many allegations at our MLAs, but we kept emerging unscathed. In many cases, the courts even passed strictures that the officers were wrong; that the agencies were biased. We'll emerge unblemished out of this fabricated liquor scam story too. And the day it happens, the anti-corruption movement will get 1,000 times stronger. These things require patience. It's politics. It's a long game.

Q. What is it about AAP that bothers the BJP?
We raise fundamental issues. I went to Gujarat once. Our team asked me to visit the schools there. I thought this was Modiji's state, surely the schools can't be bad. But believe me, I have not seen worse schools in any other part of the country. So, when we challenge them on things like this, they have a problem with us. It is not in their DNA...*inko lagta hai paisa kamaao, private school mein bhejo* (make money, send the kids to private schools). This is a dangerous mindset. No country can develop if you don't develop public schools.

Q. What is your sense of the Delhi election next year?
Now I am out, people are confident. Kejriwalji will be out soon too, people know their problems will be solved. Delhiites love Kejriwal, that's for sure.

WHERE IS THE MONEY?

A 2022 report by then Delhi chief secretary Naresh Kumar to the L-G V.K. Saxena alleged that wholesalers were promised a 12 per cent profit margin in the liquor policy if they returned 6 per cent as kickbacks to the AAP. Following this report, it was Saxena who recommended the CBI probe. Kejriwal and other AAP leaders have been vocally demanding to know, "Where is the money?" They argue that if they had taken kickbacks worth Rs 100 crore, the funds would be traceable in some form, such as jewellery, land or even property. "*Ek chavanni tak nahin mili* (not a penny was recovered)," Kejriwal has said multiple times, including in the recent Lok Sabha election campaigns. The ED claims the money was used in the Goa and Punjab elections. It has recently also said that the probe to prove Kejriwal's connection in the scam and the money trail is complete and they will put it before the court.

Meanwhile, the BJP is also on the move. Having won all seven Lok Sabha seats in Delhi by commanding margins, they are smelling blood. AAP leaders like Sisodia are confident that when it comes to the Delhi assembly election, people will switch loyalties and vote for them, as had happened in 2020. But there are six months still to go. Will the embattled party be able to sustain the fight? ■